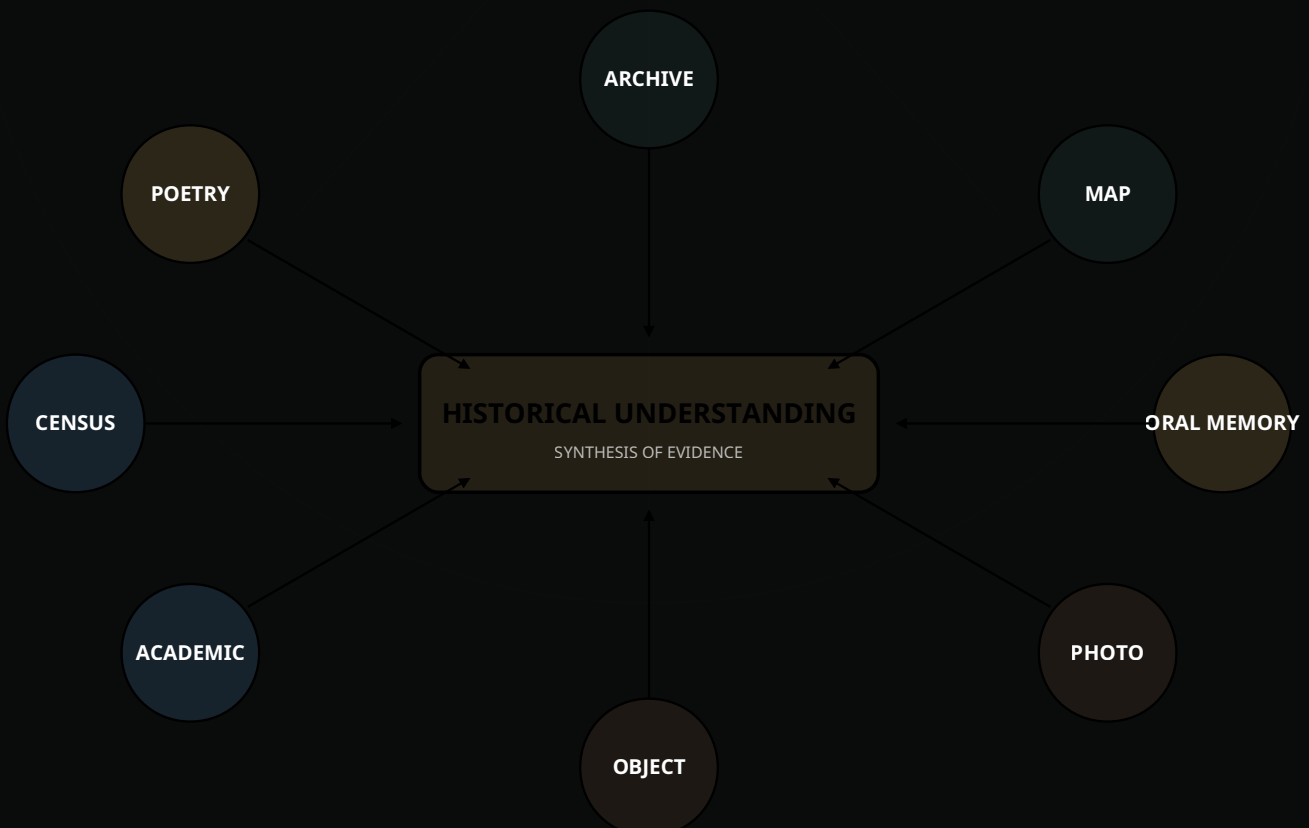


UNDERSTANDING HISTORY THROUGH MULTIPLE SOURCES

“Different sources reveal different parts of the past.”

History rarely speaks with one voice. One document may describe an event from the perspective of an administrator. A map may show the territory differently. An elder may remember what happened within a village. A family photograph may reveal details no official report recorded. An academic researcher may connect these fragments to a wider historical context. Each source sees something; each source misses something. Understanding the past therefore requires more than collecting sources—it requires comparing them. The historian's task is not to force every source to agree. It is to understand why they agree, why they differ, and what those differences reveal.



“A convergence model of historical evidence: multiple sources revealing different parts of the past.”

THE CENTRAL QUESTION

Historical research begins with a question. What happened? When did it happen? Who was involved? How was it experienced? Different sources answer different parts of the same question. An archive might establish a date, while an oral history preserves the community's experience of that date. Triangulation is the practice of comparing these evidence streams to produce a more nuanced interpretation.¹

QUESTION — EVIDENCE — COMPARISON — INTERPRETATION

“The logical progression from historical inquiry to interpretation.”

MULTIPLE SOURCES ≠ MULTIPLE INDEPENDENT SOURCES

Ten sources repeating the same uncited claim are not necessarily ten independent sources. A modern book that copies an old colonial report is not independent confirmation. Strong historical understanding requires identifying where information originated. Three documents copied from one original remain one source of information.

SOURCE COMPLEMENTARITY

Source complementarity occurs when different kinds of evidence fill each other's gaps. A colonial map might locate a settlement, but a family document might record who lived there.

By examining date, place, event, experience, and context together, a richer and more complete history of Orakzai emerges.³

DATE

PLACE

EVENT

EXPERIENCE

CONTEXT

RICHER HISTORY

“How complementary evidence streams build a stronger historical narrative.”

WHEN SOURCES CONTRADICT

Good historical writing does not hide contradictions. Disagreements between sources—whether in dates, names, or population figures—are themselves data points. They may reveal different calendar systems, geographic boundaries, or political perspectives. The historian's role is to investigate the conflict, explain the possible reasons, and report the disagreement honestly.³

CONFLICT

INVESTIGATE

EXPLAIN

REPORT

“The methodological response to conflicting historical evidence.”

TRIANGULATION & SCALE

Triangulation involves comparing multiple forms of evidence to increase confidence. However, scale matters. A claim must not be expanded beyond the geographic or temporal

scope of its evidence. One village's practice is not automatically a tribe-wide tradition, and one event in 1897 does not prove a permanent state of affairs.²

SCALE MATTERS

Evidence scope must match claim scope.

FAMILY — VILLAGE — VALLEY — DISTRICT — REGION — FRONTIER — DIASPORA

“The geographic hierarchy of evidence and claims.”

CASE STUDIES IN METHODOLOGY

Reconstructing Orakzai history requires specific methodologies for different subjects. Identifying a place requires triangulating historical maps with modern geographic data and local names. Establishing a tradition requires comparing oral accounts with historical descriptions and material evidence. Each case study demonstrates the power of multiple sources.^{4 5}

SUBJECT	EVIDENCE TYPES	GOAL
FOOD	Oral History + Nature Study (2026) + Ethnography	Identify traditional food systems and wild plant use.
MIGRATION	Family Memory + Govt Records + School Records	Reconstruct experiences of displacement and urbanization.
ORIGINS	Legend (Oral) + 1910 Dictionary + Genealogy	Understand tribal identity formation and ancestral stories.

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

History became clearer to me when I stopped looking for one perfect source. The past is too large for that. A document can give us a date; a map can give us a place; an elder can give us a

memory; a photograph can give us a face. None of these alone is the whole story. Together, when examined carefully, they can bring us closer to it. But the goal is not to make every source agree. Sometimes disagreement is itself historical evidence. It can show us how different people experienced the same event, how memory changed, or how different institutions understood the same place. For me, responsible history means listening to many voices while remaining honest about the limits of what we know. The strongest story is not always the most certain story—it is the story whose evidence can be followed.

“ONE SOURCE CAN SHOW A FRAGMENT. MANY SOURCES CAN REVEAL THE PATTERN.”

METHODOLOGICAL SYNTHESIS
